



7th Edition

Student Paper Setup Guide

This guide will help you set up an APA Style student paper. The basic setup directions apply to the entire paper. Annotated diagrams illustrate how to set up the major sections of a student paper: the title page or cover page, the text, tables and figures, and the reference list.

Basic Setup

Seventh edition APA Style was designed with modern word-processing programs in mind. Most default settings in programs such as Academic Writer, Microsoft Word, and Google Docs already comply with APA Style. However, you may need to make a few adjustments before you begin writing.

- **Margins:** Use 1-in. margins on all sides of the page (top, bottom, left, and right).
- **Font:** Use a legible font. Many fonts are acceptable, including 11-point Calibri, 11-point Arial, 12-point Times New Roman, and 11-point Georgia. The default font of your word-processing program is acceptable.
- **Line spacing:** Use double-spacing for the entire paper (including block quotations and the reference list). Do not add blank lines before or after headings. Do not add extra spacing between paragraphs.
- **Paragraph alignment and indentation:** Align paragraphs of text to the left margin. Leave the right margin ragged. Do not use full justification. Indent the first line of every paragraph of text 0.5 in. using the tab key or the paragraph-formatting function of your word-processing program.
- **Page numbers:** Put a page number in the top right corner of every page, including the title page or cover page, which is page 1. Student papers do not require a running head on any page.

Title Page Setup



Title Page Elements

	Page number	1
Paper title	Advising Psychology Majors About Graduate School in Psychology: Current Practices and Challenges	
Author names	Robert T. Schatz and Pamela I. Ansburg	
Affiliation	Department of Psychology, Metropolitan State University of Denver	
Course number and name	PSY-4510: History & Systems Psychology	
Instructor name	Dr. Mackenzie R. Teacher	
Due date	September 10, 2020	

- The affiliation consists of the department of the course and the name of the university.
- Write the course number and name and instructor name as shown on course materials.
- Use the date format used in your country for the assignment due date.
- Page number 1 appears in the top right of the page in the page header.
- No running heads are required for student papers.

Title Page Line Spacing

Double-space
whole title page

1

Place title 3 or 4 lines down
from top of page

Advising Psychology Majors About Graduate School in Psychology: Current Practices and Challenges

Extra line between title and author names

Robert T. Schatz and Pamela I. Ansborg

Department of Psychology, Metropolitan State University of Denver

PSY-4510: History & Systems Psychology

Dr. Mackenzie R. Teacher

September 10, 2020

Title Page Alignment

Right-align
page number

1

Center entire title page
(except page number)

Advising Psychology Majors About Graduate School in Psychology: Current Practices and Challenges

Robert T. Schatz and Pamela I. Ansborg

Department of Psychology, Metropolitan State University of Denver

PSY-4510: History & Systems Psychology

Dr. Mackenzie R. Teacher

September 10, 2020

Title Page Font

1

Bold paper title

Advising Psychology Majors About Graduate School in Psychology: Current Practices and Challenges

Robert T. Schatz and Pamela I. Ansborg

Department of Psychology, Metropolitan State University of Denver

PSY-4510: History & Systems Psychology

Dr. Mackenzie R. Teacher

September 10, 2020

Standard font
(no bold, no italic)
for all other title
page elements

Text Setup



Text Elements

Repeat paper title at top of first page of text

2

Advising Psychology Majors About Graduate School in Psychology: Current Practices and Challenges

Introduction

The *APA Guidelines for the Undergraduate Psychology Major* outlines strategies for psychology departments to help students discern and take steps toward their professional development goals (APA Board of Educational Affairs Task Force on Psychology Major Competencies, 2013). For many students, graduate school is fundamental to achieving postbaccalaureate success. High-quality advising can be vital in helping students gain admission to psychology graduate programs. However, little is known about the strategies that psychology departments use to advise students about graduate school. We conducted the present research to better understand these strategies.

The job outlook for psychology majors who earn graduate degrees is quite good. In fact, the demand for psychologists with graduate degrees is expected to grow much faster than the demand for

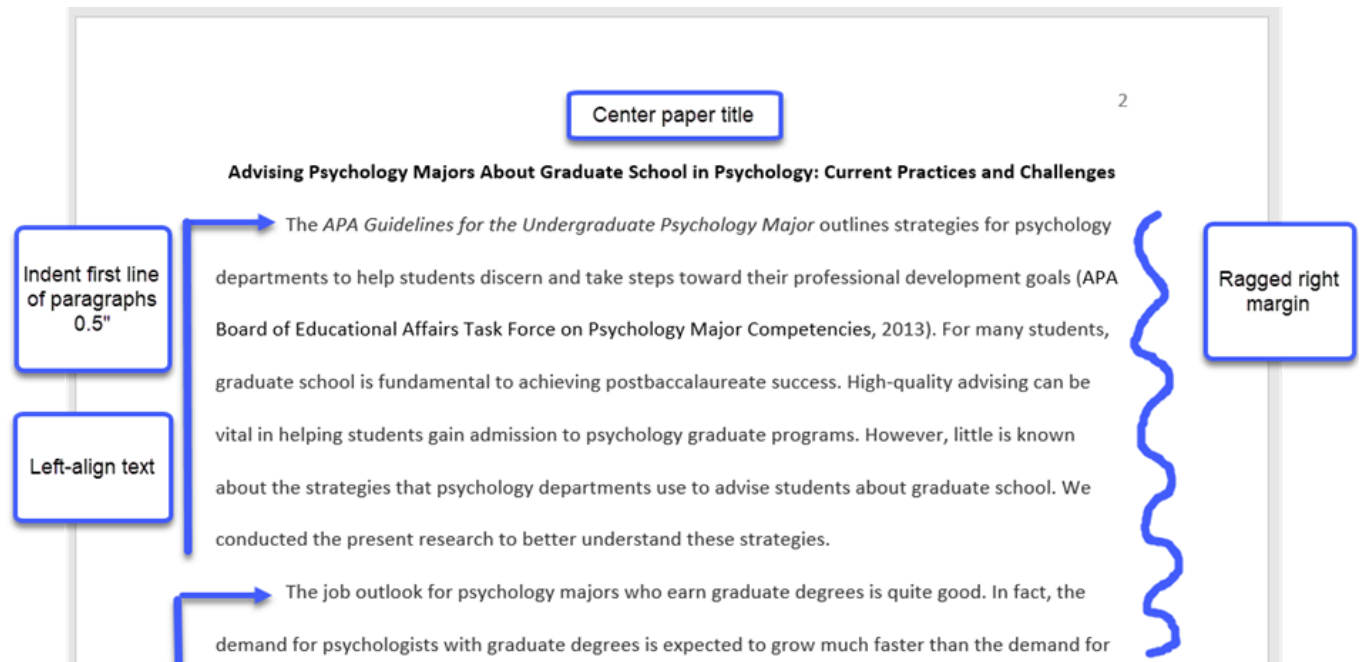
- Repeat the paper title at the top of the first page of text.
- Begin with an introduction to provide background and context.
- Use descriptive headings to identify other sections (e.g., Method, Results, Discussion for quantitative research papers).
- Sections and headings vary depending on paper type and complexity.
- Text can include tables and figures, block quotations, headings, and footnotes.

Text Line Spacing

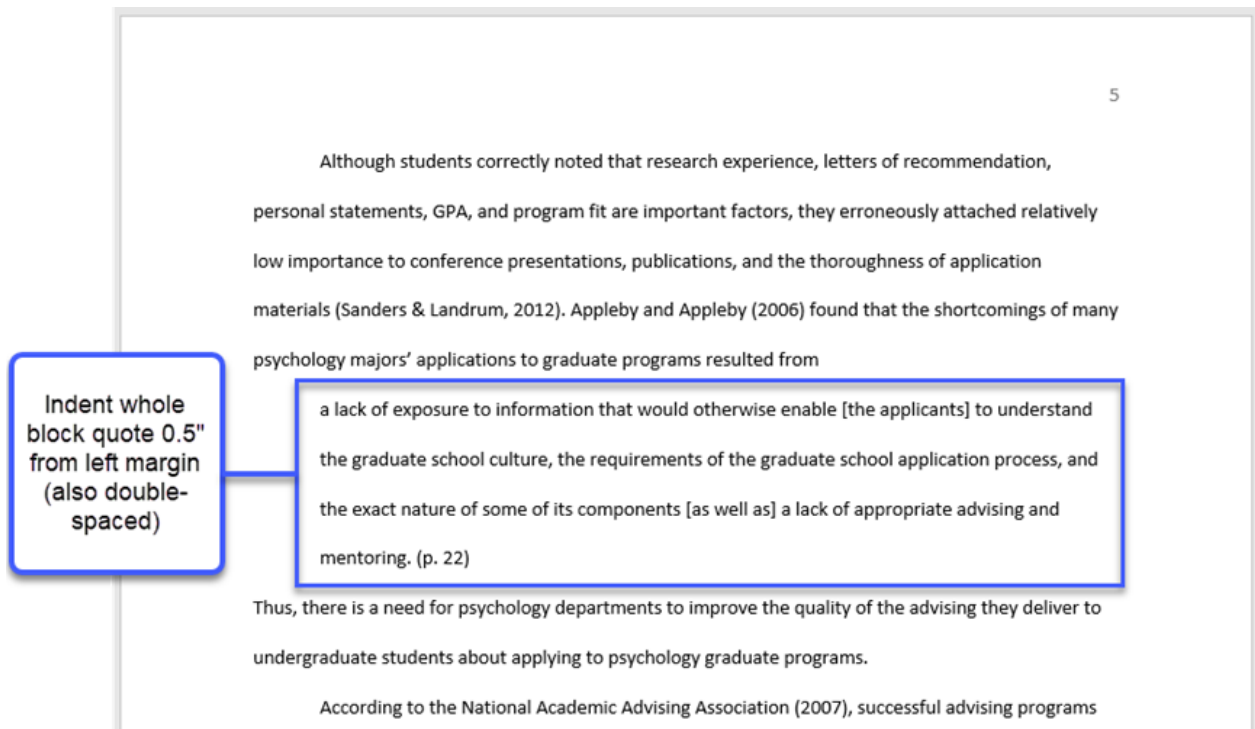
Double-space all text, including

- headings and section labels
- paragraphs of text
- block quotes

Text Alignment



Block Quotation Alignment



Text Font

- Use the same font throughout the entire paper.
- Write body text in standard (nonbold, nonitalic) font.
- Use italics sparingly, for instance, to highlight a key term on first use (see *Concise Guide to APA Style* Section 4.15).

Headings Format

Level	Format
1	Centered, Bold, Title Case Heading Text begins as a new paragraph.
2	Flush left, Bold, Title Case Heading Text begins as a new paragraph.
3	<i>Flush Left, Bold Italic, Title Case Heading</i> Text begins as a new paragraph.
4	Indented, Bold, Title Case Heading, Ending With a Period. Text begins on the same line and continues as a regular paragraph.
5	<i>Indented, Bold Italic, Title Case Heading, Ending With a Period.</i> Text begins on the same line and continues as a regular paragraph.

- **Alignment:** Center Level 1 headings. Left-align Level 2 and Level 3 headings. Indent Level 4 and Level 5 headings like a paragraph.
- **Font:** Boldface all headings. Also italicize Level 3 and Level 5 headings.
- **Tip:** Create heading styles using your word-processing program (built into Academic Writer, available for Word via [sample papers](#) on the APA Style website).

Title of Paper

Begin your paper with the paper title at the top of the first page of text. The paper title acts as a de facto Level 1 heading: It is centered and in bold title case font. Do not use the heading “Introduction”; text at the beginning of the paper is assumed to be the introduction.

APA Style headings have five possible levels. Each main section starts with the highest level of heading, even if one section has fewer levels of subheading than another section. For example, in a paper with Level 1 Method, Results, and Discussion headings, the Method and Results sections may each have two levels of subheading (Levels 2 and 3), and the Discussion section may have only one level of subheading (Level 2).

Level 2 Heading in the Introduction

Use Level 2 headings for any headings within the introduction, Level 3 for subsections of any Level 2 headings, and so on.

Level 2 Heading in the Introduction

Avoid having only one subsection heading within a section, just like in an outline. Use at least two subsection headings within a section or use no subsection headings at all (e.g., in an outline, a section numbered with a Roman numeral would be divided into either a minimum of A and B subsections or no subsections; an A subsection would not stand alone).

Level 1 Heading for First Main Section After the Introduction

After the introduction (regardless of whether it includes headings), use a Level 1 heading for the next main section of the paper (e.g., Method).

Level 2 Heading

Use Level 2 headings for subsections of Level 1 headings. Do not label headings with numbers or letters.

Level 2 Heading

All topics of equal importance should have the same level of heading. For example, in a multiexperiment paper, the headings for the Method and Results sections for Experiment 1 should be the same level as the headings for the Method and Results sections for Experiment 2, with parallel wording. In a single-experiment paper, the Method, Results, and Discussion

sections should all have the same heading level.

Level 3 Heading

Use Level 3 headings for subsections of Level 2 headings. Do not use abbreviations in headings unless they already defined in the text.

Level 3 Heading

The number of levels of heading needed for a paper depends on its length and complexity. Three levels of heading is average.

Level 4 Heading. Use Level 4 headings for subsections of Level 3 headings. Use only the number of headings necessary to differentiate distinct sections in your paper. Short student papers may not require any headings.

Level 4 Heading. It is not necessary to add blank lines before or after headings, even if a heading falls at the end of a page. Do not add extra spacing between paragraphs.

Level 5 Heading. Use Level 5 headings for subsections of Level 4 headings. In the *Publication Manual of the American Psychological Association* (7th ed.), Table 2.3 shows how to format each level of heading, Figure 2.4 demonstrates the use of headings in the introduction, and Figure 2.5 lists all the headings used in a sample paper in the correct format. In the *Concise Guide to APA Style* (7th ed.), this content is found in Table 1.3, Figure 1.3, and Figure 1.4, respectively.

Level 5 Heading. The sample papers at the end of Chapter 2 in the *Publication Manual* and Chapter 1 in the *Concise Guide* show the use of headings in context. Additional sample papers can be found on the APA Style website (<https://apastyle.apa.org>).

Tables and Figures Setup



- Only some papers have tables and figures.
- Tables and figures share the same elements.

Table Elements

Number Table 1

Title Departments' Formal Requirements for Students to Learn About Graduate School in Psychology

Body
(rows and
columns)

Answer	%	<i>n</i>
No formal requirements	47.9	78
Completion of a psychology careers course or module	35.6	58
Required meeting with a department advisor	25.2	41
Other	4.9	7
Required attendance at a presentation on psychology careers	4.3	4
Required meeting with an advisor from outside the department	1.2	2
Unsure	0.6	1

Note
(optional)

Note. The survey item read as follows: "What format requirements does your department have for students to learn about graduate school in psychology? Check all that apply."

Figure Elements

Number Figure 1

Title Participant Response Frequencies Regarding Priority of Graduate School Advising

Image



Note
(optional)

Note. The survey item read as follows: "Compared to your department's other educational goals for psychology students, how much of a priority is it to provide students advising about the process of applying to graduate school in psychology?"

Table Line Spacing

Double-space
number and title

Table 1

Departments' Formal Requirements for Students to Learn About Graduate School in Psychology

Answer	%	<i>n</i>
No formal requirements	47.9	78
Completion of a psychology careers course or module	35.6	58
Required meeting with a department advisor	25.2	41
Other	4.9	7
Required attendance at a presentation on psychology careers	4.3	4
Required meeting with an advisor from outside the department	1.2	2
Unsure	0.6	1

Single-, 1.5, or
double-spacing in
table body
(adjust as needed
for readability)

Double-space
note

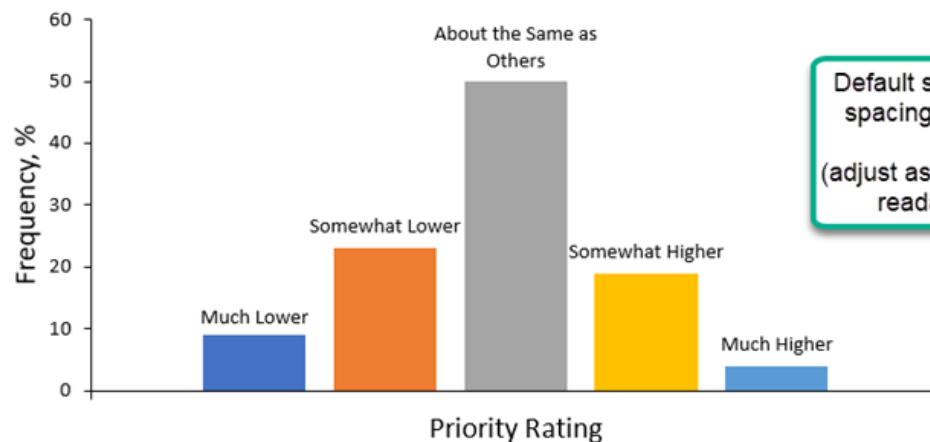
Note. The survey item read as follows: "What format requirements does your department have for students to learn about graduate school in psychology? Check all that apply."

Figure Line Spacing

Double-space
number and title

Figure 1

Participant Response Frequencies Regarding Priority of Graduate School Advising



Default settings for
spacing in image
(adjust as needed for
readability)

Double-space
note

Note. The survey item read as follows: "Compared to your department's other educational goals for psychology students, how much of a priority is it to provide students advising about the process of applying to graduate school in psychology?"

Table Alignment

Left-align
number and title

Table 1

Departments' Formal Requirements for Students to Learn About Graduate School in Psychology

Answer	%	<i>n</i>
No formal requirements	47.9	78
Completion of a psychology careers course or module	35.6	58
Required meeting with a department advisor	25.2	41
Other	4.9	7
Required attendance at a presentation on psychology careers	4.3	4
Required meeting with an advisor from outside the department	1.2	2
Unsure	0.6	1

Center table
headings

Left-align
table itself

and

Left-align
leftmost column

Center data
(if short)

or

Left-align data
(if long)

Left-align note

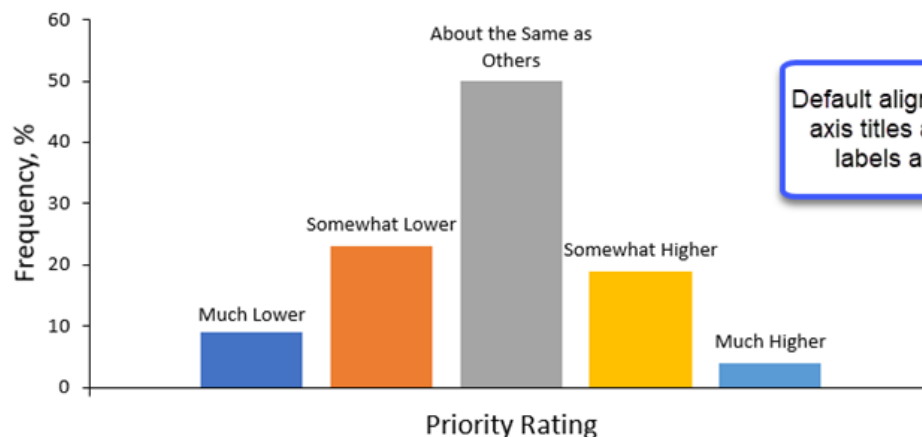
Note. The survey item read as follows: "What format requirements does your department have for students to learn about graduate school in psychology? Check all that apply."

Figure Alignment

Left-align
number and title

Figure 1

Participant Response Frequencies Regarding Priority of Graduate School Advising



Left-align whole
image (chart,
graph, etc.)

Default alignments for
axis titles and data
labels are fine

Left-align note

Note. The survey item read as follows: "Compared to your department's other educational goals for psychology students, how much of a priority is it to provide students advising about the process of applying to graduate school in psychology?"

Table Font

Bold number Table 1

Italic title Departments' Formal Requirements for Students to Learn About Graduate School in Psychology

Answer	%	<i>n</i>
No formal requirements	47.9	78
Completion of a psychology careers course or module	35.6	58
Required meeting with a department advisor	25.2	41
Other	4.9	7
Required attendance at a presentation on psychology careers	4.3	4
Required meeting with an advisor from outside the department	1.2	2
Unsure	0.6	1

Same font
as paper in
table body

Italic "Note" Note. The survey item read as follows: "What format requirements does your department have for students to learn about graduate school in psychology? Check all that apply."

Same font
as paper in
note text

Figure Font

Bold number Figure 1

Italic title Participant Response Frequencies Regarding Priority of Graduate School Advising



Sans serif font
(e.g., Calibri, Arial)
in image,
size 8-14 pt
(default settings
are fine)

Italic "Note" Note. The survey item read as follows: "Compared to your department's other educational goals for psychology students, how much of a priority is it to provide students advising about the process of applying to graduate school in psychology?"

Same font
as paper in
note text

Placement of Tables and Figures

You can embed tables and figures in the body of the paper.

This guide shows options for placement. If your instructor requires tables and figures to be placed at the end of the paper, see examples in the *Publication Manual* and in the professional sample paper on the APA Style website.

- Embed tables and figures in the text.
- Call out (mention) the table or figure in the text before embedding it.
- Place the table or figure after the callout
 - at the bottom of the page
 - at the top of the next page
 - by itself on the next page
- Avoid placing tables and figures in the middle of the page.

Embedding at the Bottom of the Page

estimates (American Psychological Association, 2016; Halonen, 2011). Respondents evaluated the

relative priority of graduate school advising versus other priorities (see Figure 1).

Callout in text before
table or figure

Blank line between text
and table or figure at
bottom of page

Figure 1

Participant Response Frequencies Regarding Priority of Graduate School Advising



Embedding at the Top of the Page

Callout in text before
table or figure

Table 1 presents responses to the question regarding formal requirements for students to learn about graduate school in participants' home departments. A little more than a third of departments required students to complete a careers or professional development course or course module(s) that included information about graduate school, and 25% of departments required that students meet with a department advisor about graduate school. Forty-eight percent of participants indicated that their department had no formal requirements for students to learn about graduate school.

6

Table or figure is at
top of page

Table 1

Departments' Formal Requirements for Students to Learn About Graduate School in Psychology

Answer	%	<i>n</i>
No formal requirements	47.9	78
Completion of a psychology careers course or module	35.6	58
Required meeting with a department advisor	25.2	41
Other	4.9	7
Required attendance at a presentation on psychology careers	4.3	4
Required meeting with an advisor from outside the department	1.2	2
Unsure	0.6	1

Note. The survey item read as follows: "What format requirements does your department have for students to learn about graduate school in psychology? Check all that apply."

Blank line between
end of table or figure
and more text

Table 2 shows participants' perceptions regarding the most common way that students in their department learn about the psychology graduate school application process. Over half of the

Embedding on Its Own Page

8

Table 4

Challenges or Barriers to Advising Students About Applying to Graduate School in Psychology

Challenge	%	<i>n</i>	Example
Disseminating information	32	52	We need to get information to students effectively.
Faculty time and resources	20	33	We each have 30 to 40 advisees.
Student effort or initiative	7	12	Students need to be more proactive.
Student constraints	7	12	Many students cannot leave the area due to family responsibilities.
Student planning and timelines	7	12	Students get involved in research too late.
Student interest	6	9	Not all students are interested in graduate school.
Student resources	5	8	We do not have adequate research and field work opportunities for all interested students.
Assessment	4	7	There is no easy way to track students or follow up to find out who actually applies to graduate school.
Faculty interest and motivation	4	6	Some faculty do not encourage students to apply.

- Embed long tables or large figures on their own page if needed.
- Text continues on the next page.

Reference List Setup



Reference List Elements

Alphabetical list of references

"References"
section label

9

References

APA Board of Educational Affairs Task Force on Psychology Major Competencies. (2013). *APA guidelines for the undergraduate psychology major* (Version 2.0).
<https://www.apa.org/ed/precollege/about/psymajor-guidelines.pdf>

Appleby, D. C., & Appleby, K. M. (2006). Kisses of death in the graduate school application process. *Teaching of Psychology*, 33(1), 19–24. https://doi.org/10.1207/s15328023top3301_5

Halonen, J. S. (2011). *Are there too many psychology majors?* [White paper]. Council of Graduate Departments of Psychology.
[https://www.cogdop.org/page_attachments/0000/0199/FLA White Paper for cogop posting.pdf](https://www.cogdop.org/page_attachments/0000/0199/FLA%20White%20Paper%20for%20cogop%20posting.pdf)

Patton, M. Q. (1990). *Qualitative evaluation and research methods* (2nd ed.). Sage Publications.

- View [reference examples](#) on the APA Style website
- Consult Chapter 10 for even more examples.

Reference List Line Spacing

Start reference list
at top of a new
page after text

9

References

Double-space the
entire reference list

(both within and
between entries)

APA Board of Educational Affairs Task Force on Psychology Major Competencies. (2013). *APA guidelines for the undergraduate psychology major* (Version 2.0).

<https://www.apa.org/ed/precollege/about/psymajor-guidelines.pdf>

Appleby, D. C., & Appleby, K. M. (2006). Kisses of death in the graduate school application process.

Teaching of Psychology, 33(1), 19–24. https://doi.org/10.1207/s15328023top3301_5

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Ware, M. E., Busch-Rossnagel, N. A., Crider, A. B., Gray-Shellberg, L., Hale, K., Lloyd, M. A., Rivera-

Medina, E., & Sgro, J. A. (1993). Developing and improving advising: Challenges to prepare

Reference List Alignment

Center the bold
"References" label

9

References

Hanging indent of
0.5" on all reference
entries

Create hanging
indent with your
word-processing
program

(do not manually hit
enter and tab keys)

APA Board of Educational Affairs Task Force on Psychology Major Competencies. (2013). *APA guidelines for the undergraduate psychology major* (Version 2.0).

<https://www.apa.org/ed/precollege/about/psymajor-guidelines.pdf>

Appleby, D. C., & Appleby, K. M. (2006). Kisses of death in the graduate school application process.

Teaching of Psychology, 33(1), 19–24. https://doi.org/10.1207/s15328023top3301_5

Halonen, J. S. (2011). *Are there too many psychology majors?* [White paper]. Council of Graduate Departments of Psychology.

[https://www.cogdop.org/page_attachments/0000/0199/FLA White Paper for cogop posting.pdf](https://www.cogdop.org/page_attachments/0000/0199/FLA%20White%20Paper%20for%20cogop%20posting.pdf)

Patton, M. Q. (1990). *Qualitative evaluation and research methods* (2nd ed.). Sage Publications.

Ware, M. E., Busch-Rossnagel, N. A., Crider, A. B., Gray-Shellberg, L., Hale, K., Lloyd, M. A., Rivera-

Medina, E., & Sgro, J. A. (1993). Developing and improving advising: Challenges to prepare

Reference List Font

Bold "References" label at top
of first page of references

9

References

APA Board of Educational Affairs Task Force on Psychology Major Competencies. (2013). *APA guidelines for the undergraduate psychology major* (Version 2.0).

<https://www.apa.org/ed/precollege/about/psymajor-guidelines.pdf>

Appleby, D. C., & Appleby, K. M. (2006). Kisses of death in the graduate school application process.

Teaching of Psychology, 33(1), 19–24. https://doi.org/10.1207/s15328023top3301_5

Halonen, J. S. (2011). *Are there too many psychology majors?* [White paper]. Council of Graduate Departments of Psychology.

[https://www.cogdop.org/page_attachments/0000/0199/FLA White Paper for cogop posting.pdf](https://www.cogdop.org/page_attachments/0000/0199/FLA%20White%20Paper%20for%20cogop%20posting.pdf)

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Medina, E., & Sgro, J. A. (1993). Developing and improving advising: Challenges to prepare

students for life. In T. V. McGovern (Ed.), *Handbook for enhancing undergraduate education in psychology* (pp. 47–70). American Psychological Association. <https://doi.org/10.1037/10126-002>

Italics in reference
entries either

on the title
(e.g., webpages,
books, reports)

or

on the source
(e.g., journal articles,
edited book chapters)



7th Edition

Heading Levels Template: Student Paper

The following template demonstrates how to use heading levels in an APA Style student paper.

Please note that the page numbers in this template are part of the template; that is, the text of a student paper should start on page 2, after the title page.

Final Checks

Check Page Order

- Start each section on a new page.
- Arrange pages in the following order:
 - Title page (page 1)
 - Text (starts on page 2)
 - Reference list (starts on a new page after the text)



Check Headings

- Check that headings accurately reflect the content in each section.
- Start each main section with a Level 1 heading.
- Use Level 2 headings for subsections of the introduction.
- Use the same level of heading for sections of equal importance.
- Avoid having only one subsection within a section (have two or more, or none).

Check Assignment Instructions

- Instructors' guidelines supersede APA Style.
- Students should check their assignment guidelines or rubric for specific content to include in their papers and to make sure they are meeting assignment requirements.

Tips for Better Writing

- Ask for feedback on your paper from a classmate, writing center tutor, or instructor.
- Budget time to implement suggestions.
- Use spell-check and grammar-check to identify potential errors.
- Proofread the paper by reading it slowly and carefully aloud to yourself.
- Consult your university writing center if you need extra help.



AMERICAN PSYCHOLOGICAL ASSOCIATION

More information on student papers can be found in the *Publication Manual of the American Psychological Association* (7th ed.) and in the *Concise Guide to APA Style* (7th ed.).

SOURCE: American Psychological Association. (2020). *Publication manual of the American Psychological Association* (7th ed.). <https://doi.org/10.1037/0000165-000>

Last updated 10/21/2020